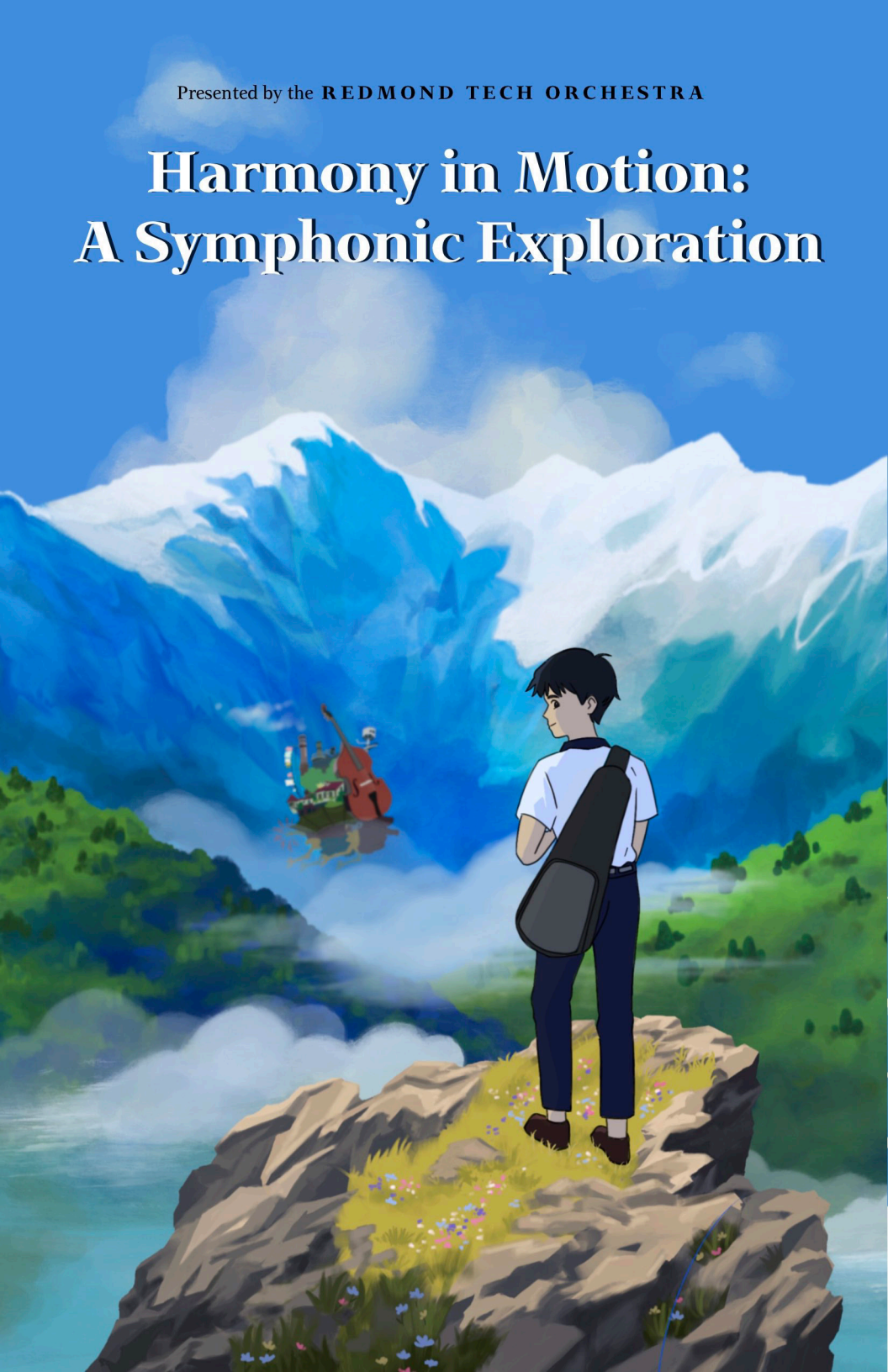
Presented by the **REDMOND TECH ORCHESTRA**

Harmony in Motion: A Symphonic Exploration



Joe Hisaishi
Symphonic Variation “Merry-go-round” (14’)

Antonín Dvořák
Carnival Overture, Op. 92 (10’)

Intermission

Antonín Dvořák
Symphony No. 9 in E Minor “From the New World,” Op. 9 (40’)

Program Notes

Joe Hisaishi’s symphonic variation *Merry-go-Round of Life*, arranged as a concert version of his original score for Hayao Miyazaki’s 2004 film *Howl’s Moving Castle*, beautifully captures the essence of the story through music. The Japanese composer, music director, conductor, and pianist has been associated with director and animator Miyazaki since 1984, having written scores for all but one of Miyazaki’s films. This lilting piece features a catchy, memorable waltz that instantly draws listeners in with its enchanting melody. As the music progresses, it slows down and takes on a more solemn and majestic tone, serving as a metaphor for the journey from the carefree joys of childhood to the more profound and complex experiences of adulthood. This transformation within the music mirrors the film’s narrative, making it a deeply moving and evocative composition. Our conductor doubles as the pianist for this score, leading the orchestra while performing on stage alongside the orchestra for the first time.

Antonin Dvořák’s *Carnival Overture*, published 1891, is the second piece in his triptych orchestral work originally titled *Nature, Life, and Love*. This fast paced overture is characterized by its exuberance, high spirits, and tenderness, interspersed with occasional shadows, all wrapped in the airy musical texture that is uniquely Dvořák. Midway through its sonata-form structure, the piece features a pastoral, open-air interlude: where the clarinet references the “nature theme” and a languidly beautiful melody is passed from flute to violin, adding a serene contrast to the aggressively energetic sections. The title [carnival] alludes to the pre-Lenten season celebrated vibrantly around the world, culminating in Mardi Gras, capturing the festive and colorful spirit of these celebrations.

Symphony No. 9, also known as the "New World Symphony," was composed in 1893 during Antonin Dvořák's first year in the United States as director of the National Conservatory of Music of America, and achieved immediate and lasting success. Dubbed as one of the most versatile composers of his time, the Czech composer was renowned for incorporating folk music into 19th-century Romantic compositions. This four-movement symphony retains a distinctly European style while incorporating themes that evoke American traditions. The most notable of these is found in the second movement, where the English horn plays an African American spiritual-like tune.

The first movement, *Allegro molto*, is written in sonata form and begins with a slow Adagio introduction, establishing a leitmotif of Dvořák's American period. *Largo's* main theme, a broad and simple melody played by the English horn against muted strings, gives rise to images of the vast American prairies, an Indian lament, and homesickness. The third movement, *Molto vivace*, is in A–B–A form and is inspired by the "feast where the Indians dance" from Longfellow's poem Hiawatha, featuring a dynamic coda that recalls the first movement's closing theme. The final movement, *Allegro con fuoco*, revisits themes from previous movements, showcasing Dvořák's principle of reminiscence. Despite drawing inspiration from folk music, Dvořák insisted he borrowed no actual melodies, resulting in a symphony filled with memorable tunes. Years later, William Fisher, one of Dvořák's students, added lyrics to the second movement's theme, creating the popular song "Goin' Home." The symphony is considered a major milestone in the use of American music as source material for classical composition.

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